

Slide 1 – Introduction - Baudrillard and news MECS3004

Baudrillard

Context of postmodernism

1. Baudrillard is a French intellectual post-modern critic and is an extreme proponent of post-modernity.
1. He looks at how our post-modern world is no longer real but only a **simulation of the real**

Hyperreality, simulacra and mass media

1. He looks at ideas of **hyperreality, simulacra** and the mass media
2. Sometimes people use the **word hyper** to refer to an excess beyond the norm rather than anything unreal
3. Baudrillard uses the term to mean the condition of postmodernity where the **simulacra are no longer** associated with anything real - Where the **signs, images and models** that circulate have become **detached** from any real material object

Signs have replaced reality

1. Baudrillard claims our society has **replaced all reality** and meaning with **symbols and signs**
2. All we know as real is actually a **simulation of reality**
3. The world is composed of **simulations of reality** which exist in layers and cannot be traced back to their original subjects (if these exist)

Simulacra

1. The **world is saturated by imagery**, infused with media, sound and advertising.
2. This simulacra of the real surpasses the real world and thus becomes **hyperreal** - A world that is **more real than real**.

Representation of things come to replace those things

1. Simulation is where the representation of things come to replace the things being represented i.e. we think that the **representations** are more important than the 'real.'

Postmodernism – signs predominate in the media

1. Postmodernist talk of stories or narratives, **refer to the stories we tell ourselves** about the way reality works
2. Knowledge has a plural character- There are **knowledge or truths** rather than the truth or knowledge
3. Signs predominate and hence any distinction between appearances and reality is lost.
4. The **overproduction of signs by the** media wipes out any distinction between the **image and the reality** and leads to **the loss of any stable meaning**.

Baudrillard – postmodern culture (a world of signs)

1. Baudrillard's concept of simulation is the **creation of the real through conceptual or "mythological"** models which have **no connection** or **origin** in reality.

Simulacra – copy without an original (Disneyland)

Simulacra part I

1. Baudrillard uses the concepts of the **simulacra--the copy without an original--and simulation**.

Simulacra part II

1. These are **similar to simulations**, but they go one step further.
2. **Simulacra are copies of things that no longer have an original** (or never had one to begin with). e.g., Disneyland's Main Street USA
3. Ideas about simulacra are part of the post-modern notion of worlds without origins and a world "without depth, a world of surface."

Phases of representation

The image is the reflection of a profound reality -Where the image is a **good reflection of reality**

The images masks a profound reality -The image is an **inadequate reflection** of reality

The image **masks the absence of a profound reality** -This is make believe and deception

The image is **bears no relation to any reality – it is its own pure simulacrum**

Slide Hyperreality

World of hyperreality (distinction between real and unreal are blurred)

1. Thus the **boundary** between the **image, or simulation**, and reality implodes (breaks down).
2. This creates a **world of hyperreality** where the distinctions between real and unreal are blurred.
3. The **culture industry blurs the lines between facts and information**, between **information and entertainment**, between **entertainment and politics**.
4. The masses get bombarded by these **images (simulations)** and **signs (simulacra)** which encourage them to buy, vote, work, play,... but eventually they become apathetic (i.e. cynical).

Collapse of all boundaries

1. Because simulations and simulacra ultimately have no referents, the social begins to implode.
2. This process of **social entropy** leads to the **collapse of all boundaries** between meaning, the media, and the social- no distinction between classes, political parties, cultural forms, the media, **and the real**.

News is about immediacy

News

1. The news is part of the **daily flow** of television. It is why some channels exist e.g. CNN

2. Television news is carefully produced and structured according to **routines** follows **traditional narrative**
3. News is about **immediacy**

News values

News and how Events become part of news

1. How events become part of the news depends on **news values**
2. Once they have become news and while they remain news, their reportage depends on codes of representation and journalistic practices
3. Galtung and Ruge (1965) – attempted to identify categories related to newsworthiness

Fake News

1. This is where disinformation can spread by news media and also social media.
2. Often the fake news then finds its way into mainstream media.
3. Some stories make advertising revenue from clicks they get from fake news.
4. Hostile government actors have also been implicated in generating and propagating fake news.

Types

1. May be news satire which introduces non-factual elements
2. May be a false connection, or misleading content
3. The content could be manipulated to deceive
4. The content could be shared with false contextual information
5. Or indeed completely fabricated

Origins

1. Fake news – propaganda was used during the first and second world war.
2. Orson Welles - War of the Worlds broadcast created panic, with people believing an alien invasion had happened

21st Century

1. The internet has enabled more access to information and therefore more chance for fake news.
2. News consumption is personalised and bots have the potential to increase the spread of fake news, using algorithms to decide what articles and information specific users like

Television in the 1960s – Politics

1. Boorstin called political debates of Kennedy and Nixon a pseudo-event - A staged event selected to present to others
2. Television on a small screen magnifies the face

Presenting oneself

1. From 1988 to 2004 Trump made cameo appearances as himself on 14 sitcoms and also in 12 films. In all of these he promoted himself as a successful businessman- Despite filing for four bankruptcies.
2. He was a Democrat until 1987 and became a registered Republican.
3. He returned to the Democrats until 2008 and then rejoined the Republicans
4. He received unprecedented media coverage – the key factor was his television celebrity association with 14 years of exposure on NBCs apprentice and other self promotion

The Apprentice

1. This aired 2004 to 2014 and projected a positive image of Trump as if he were a super successful billionaire businessman
2. During this time he was fighting lawsuits, losing support from banks on loans.
3. Television has the power to shape an image with the continue repetition of selected characteristics about a person

Politics Dramas

Brexit and TV

1. The Uncivil war – looked at the events of Brexit from the point of view of the Leave campaign director, Dominic Cummings –
2. There have been other dramas focusing on politics –e.g. *the Thick of It*.
3. Comedies also focus on politics – e.g. *The News Quiz*.

War

1. War is another area where it is hard to know what is actually going on
 2. On the ground
 3. So we can **relate ideas** such as **simulation** and **simulacra** to war reporting on news.
 4. War is conducted as a **media spectacle** -Rehearsed as a wargame or simulation -Which is enacted for the **audience as a simulation**
- News event**
- As a news event there are all sort of things going on e.g. Such as the **journalists viewpoint**.
 - The **missile's eye view video** cameras which you sometimes see in **video games**

Medical Dramas and fictional worlds

1. CPR is often misrepresented on television, Particularly in relation to how effective it is at resuscitating someone who is not breathing
2. A third of patients given **CPR are ever** discharged from hospital – **the rest die**.

3. Doctors from the BMA warn that **TV drama resuscitation rates** are much higher than those in reality
1. Similarly, nurses claim that programmes like **Holby City** are encouraging patients to **believe in miracles** and giving them **false hopes**
2. So you could apply the notion of such **programmes taking over reality and becoming reality perhaps** in relation to some medical issues –

Food and hyperreality

- Some argue that food itself is a **simulacrum**
 - Particularly as it relates to food in terms of **appearance** and the associated **meanings** with food e.g. Such as **food-diet, food-nature** and **food-beauty**
 - Where we experience food in a **virtual sense** through food and cookery programmes
 - **How do these relate to Baudrillard and simulacra**
- Although a real situation is represented – the **limits and defects** that occur in reality are not present
- There are no imperfections or **irregularities**.
- The cooking programmes often have no sense of time in **terms of lunch, dinner etc.**
- They strive for **aesthetic perfection** and pleasure **through food**

Other models of reality/unreality

Challenge to Baudrillard – the Onion model of reality

1. This model instead of collapsing entirely, suggests that there are **layers of reality** which are dependent on and inclusive of each other
2. The **core layer** – is slightly more stable whereas the **surface realities** are **more transient** and volatile.
3. In relation to Baudrillard – the outer layers are the ones that can change and collapse. and perhaps replace our perception of reality
4. But in this model there is a slightly **more stable core** – which can also change but it takes time

Other concepts of reality

1. Mimesis is defined as a **figure of speech** where the words or actions of another are imitated
2. It was **seen as inferior** to that **which was being imitated** – the work of art that is mass produced is inferior to the original (Sunflowers)
3. It also **produces appearances and illusions** that influence the perception and behaviour of people

Aristotle and mimesis

1. Mimesis not only **recreates existing objects** or elements of nature, but also beautifies, **improves** upon them

2. It creates a **fictional world of representation** where there is **no capacity for a non-mediated** relationship to reality
3. Mimesis - Adorno uses the concept to view how a subject **makes oneself similar to another** – and hence not just about imitation
4. Mimesis **constructs a world of illusion**, appearances, **aesthetics and images** in which existing worlds are **appropriated, changed** and **re-interpreted**.
5. Images are a part of our **material existence** but also bind our **experience of reality to subjectivity**

The end of postmodernism

1. Some academics are arguing that postmodernism has ended
2. The digital revolution suggested that a new philosophical paradigm is needed
3. But theories are currently vague and not developed
4. And often still refer to social and cultural dimensions of postmodern culture

Different ideas

1. **dominant, residual and emergent where** residual as elements of culture formed in the past but still active in the present
2. Emergent are aspects of culture which are alternative or oppositional to dominant culture
3. Culture is complex and consists of these contradictory elements – dominant, residual and emergent elements.

Terminology

1. There are disagreements about whether modern life should be described as
2. Modernity, postmodernity, post-post modernity or something else.
3. Some highlight the notion of **authenticism** - search for the authentic and the true (e.g. highlighting fake news).
4. Whichever age we are entering (and there are numerous other terminologies used) we can see how the ideas of Baudrillard can be applied to many different TV genres and to our contemporary society (whatever we call it).